



WOMEN AND MONEY

panelists debate. *Senior Correspondent* JHILMIL MOTIHAR listens in.

What does money mean to you?

Kaku Nakhate: Women view money more as security. When they make their early investments, they always think of putting the money in a safe haven. As they grow in their careers, their horizons expand. Traditionally men have been the decision makers when it comes to money and women have taken care of the home. But while women have now taken on a decisive role in investing, I don't think men have developed a sense of domestic responsibility.

Anjali Bansal: For younger women in the workforce, money also means economic independence.

Amit Tandon: Money means security for everyone, irrespective of gender. When it comes to men and women under 30, there's no difference in the way they spend. But as they grow older, women become more focused on security. Credit card company surveys show that before the age of 30, both men and women default on their credit card payments equally and after 30 it is the men who are more likely to default, as women start thinking about their family.

Traditionally, women are considered savers and men spenders. Is this

a result of social convention or a natural-born condition?

Reeta Gupta: Men are considered providers and so, have to prove themselves. Women, on the other hand, can be flirtatious with money.

Bansal: I don't think men have a choice with money. They have to work and be the primary breadwinners for the family. Women can choose to work or not to work. They are not expected to be economic producers. So yes, that is social conditioning.

Uday Sankar Roy: To a certain ex-



usually the woman, she can spend her money or save it as she pleases. I know a lot of households where the woman's income goes entirely into savings.

Nakhate: There is a generational change. Young women are very clear that they want to be independent. Today the woman isn't sure when, who and if she wants to marry. How she manages her finances now indicates what she wants to do in the long run.

Are women still dependent on men for financial planning?

Bansal: Surveys suggest that in younger, double-income units, decision making on consumption, investment or saving is a joint exercise. That said, capital market-related decisions like mutual fund investments still fall within the purview of the man, unlike hard assets like property, in which the woman is part of the decision-making process. Buying large assets may also involve the extended family.

Roy: Medium-term risks are covered by the woman's instinct and long-term ones by the man's.

Gupta: A lot of how both handle their finances depends on the time at hand. In a family unit, women would rather complete work and go back to the kids, while the man would spend that extra time researching, discussing and evaluating investments or talking

WHEN IT COMES TO MEN AND WOMEN UNDER THE AGE OF 30, THERE IS LITTLE DIFFERENCE IN THE WAY THEY SPEND. BUT AFTER 30, WOMEN TEND TO FOCUS ON SECURITY.



tent, the perception is true, but with more women entering the workplace, it is changing. It also depends on where you come from. In south India, I saw people spend what they could not save. In the east, they save if they can, but try to spend everything.

Are women now spending without having to worry about saving for the family and home?

Tandon: A woman's first instinct is to save more, but if it's for the family then a man doesn't think differently.

Roy: It depends on who the primary breadwinner in the family is. If the woman is the primary earner, then she behaves like a 'man'. The secondary earner doesn't have the responsibility of the family. Since that is

to friends about options.

Tandon: Since women have gained financial independence only recently, they tend to invest in what they may have heard about from their fathers. So even now they tend to stick to fixed deposits and savings accounts.

Are men and women spending equally, especially on luxury goods?

Tandon: I think it's a myth that men's clothes and shoes are cheaper. Sometimes they are more expensive, in case of designerwear. Women can get clothes stitched, while men can't.

Bansal: But men do think women spend more on clothes, shoes, bags and jewellery.

Tandon: Jewellery, though, is an investment unless it's only trinkets.